

ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

BACKGROUND

The players are drawn to the Hollow Dominion by a shared dream — a vision of a dying god calling for help. Upon arrival, they discover the kingdom is cursed by the death-throes of **Mordath, the Dreaming God**. The landscape warps unpredictably, nightmare creatures stalk the roads, and the populace is divided between those fighting to survive and those who've given in to madness.

The players discover they are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness, marked by a glowing sigil. They cannot leave until the curse is broken — and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him.

The adventure spans **three parts**: arrival at the Ashen Gate, investigation in the town of Drearym, and the climactic assault on the Gatehouse of Dreams. Along the way, the party must navigate faction politics, rescue the innocent, and uncover the truth behind the curse — all while the land itself tries to consume them.

ADVENTURE DETAILS

System*D&D 5e*

Levels*1–3*

Sessions*3–4*

Players*3–5*

Tone*Dark fantasy mystery*

Play Time*8–12 hours*

FACTIONS

Waking Guard*Soldiers maintaining order*

Dreamseekers*Cultists seeking freedom*

Veil Court*Surviving nobility*

The Unbound*Nightmare-consumed victims*

ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

"For three nights running, you've had the same dream. A vast chamber of white stone, a figure on a throne robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. It speaks: 'Come. Please. Before it is too late.' On the fourth day, you each find a mark on your skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon."

The sigil is the **Dreambound Mark**. It glows purple in darkness, burns near dream-energy, and cannot be removed by any means short of breaking the curse. NPCs in the Dominion can identify it immediately.

DM

NOTE

The Dreambound Mark is both a curse and a tool. It allows the bearer to sense dream-energy (detect as a bonus action, 30ft range) but also makes them visible to nightmare creatures in darkness. Use this tension throughout the adventure.

PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion — and the point of no return

DANGER

ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

The Ashen Gate is the only known entrance to the Hollow Dominion. Passing through it is a one-way trip — the gate does not allow return travel. The purple energy is raw dream-stuff leaking from Mordath's dying mind. Characters who touch it must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or experience a brief, disorienting vision of Mordath's throne room.

ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

An old man in a tattered guard's uniform sits on a stone beside the gate, whittling a piece of wood. Half-mad but sharp. He looks up as you approach, eyes narrowing at your glowing sigils.

"You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**

The landscape warps unpredictably — paths change, distances stretch

Nightmare creatures emerge at dusk from thin points in reality

The **Waking Guard** maintain order in Drearym; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead

"Don't sleep near running water — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."

Three days' travel from the Gate to Drearym along the Twisted Road

ELDON VOSS — THE GATEKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL GOOD

STR

10

+0

DEX

8

-1

CON

12

+1

INT

14

+2

WIS

16

+3

CHA

11

+0

AC 11 (leather scraps) | **HP** 18 (2d8+4) | **Speed** 30 ft.

Skills: Insight +5, Perception +5, Survival +5

Senses: Passive Perception 15

Languages: Common

Dreamsense. Eldon can detect dream-energy within 60 feet. He knows the location of all nightmare creatures within range in darkness.

Fragmented Mind. Eldon has advantage on saves against being frightened, but disadvantage on saves against charm and illusion effects.

Actions: *Club.* +2 to hit, 1d4 bludgeoning. *Information (1/day).* Eldon can reveal one useful fact about the Dominion, its history, or its dangers. The DM should provide genuine, actionable intelligence.

DM

NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain of the Waking Guard. The curse broke his mind but fragments of wisdom remain. Treat him with kindness and he's a valuable source of information — he knows the safe paths, the dangerous thin points, and the general layout of the Twisted March. If the party is hostile, he becomes incoherent and unhelpful.

THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

DANGER

THE TWISTED ROAD

The road from the Ashen Gate to Drearym is called the **Twisted March** — a three-day journey through forest that has been warped by Mordath's dying dreams. Trees grow at impossible angles. Streams run purple. The distance between landmarks changes depending on the time of day.

Travel Pace: The party travels 12 miles per day (reduced from the normal 24 due to the warping). Each day, roll on the **Random Events Table** below. At night, the DM should roll a **d6** — on a 1-2, a **Nightmare Spawn** encounter occurs during the watch.

RANDOM EVENTS (ROLL D8 EACH DAY)

D8	EVENT
1	Shifting Path: The road doubles back on itself. DC 12 Survival check to navigate correctly. Failure costs 1d4 hours and one level of exhaustion.
2	Dream Echo: Ghostly overlay of the Dominion before the curse — green fields, blue sky, children playing. One player (random) sees a vision of Mordath before he began dying: serene, kind, creating dreams for mortals. DC 13 WIS save or gain 1 level of exhaustion from emotional overwhelm.
3	Nightmare Spawn: A Nightmare Wolf (use Wolf stat block, HP 18, Bite +4, 2d4+2 piercing + 1d4 psychic, immune to charm) attacks from the treeline. It flees at half HP.
4	Traveler: A refugee named Pella Dunn (female human commoner, frightened but unharmed) warns that Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound in eastern villages. She's fleeing to Drearym. Can be a recurring NPC.
5	Dream Shimmer: One player (highest WIS) phases partially into Mordath's dream. They see a white throne room, a dying god on a cracked throne, and hear: "Find the three keys. The Architect... the Crown... the Heart..." DC 14 WIS save or take 2d6 psychic damage.
6	Waking Guard Outpost: A fortified camp of 4 Waking Guard soldiers (use Guard stat block). They offer safe rest, rations, and information about Drearym. Captain Ashford has posted them here to watch the road.
7	Thin Point: A pool of purple liquid bubbles up from the ground. Dream-energy radiates from it (10ft radius). Any Dreambound who touches it must make a DC 13 CON save or be pulled into a brief dream vision (DM's choice: lore, foreshadowing, or a glimpse of Book 2 locations).
8	Peaceful Stretch: The warping subsides for a few hours. The party finds a clearing with clean water and edible mushrooms. Everyone recovers one level of exhaustion (if any) and gains the benefit of a short rest.

NIGHT ENCOUNTERS (ROLL D6 AT NIGHT)

D6	ENCOUNTER
1-2	Nightmare Spawn: 1d4+1 Nightmare Wolves attack the camp.
3-4	Dream Whispers: All sleeping characters must make DC 12 WIS saves. Failure: no benefit from the long rest, gain 1 level of exhaustion.
5	Unbound Patrol: 2 Unbound (use Zombie stat block, but they deal psychic instead of bludgeoning damage and are immune to sleep) shamble past the camp. Stealth check DC 13 to avoid detection.
6	Quiet Night: Nothing attacks, but one character on watch sees a distant purple glow on the horizon — the Gatehouse of Dreams, miles away.

"The land remembers what it was. Sometimes, at the edges of your vision, you can see it — green fields, blue sky, children playing. Then you blink, and it's all twisted again."

MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map — Ashen Gate to Drearym



The Twisted March — The ruined tower of Valdris, a landmark halfway between the Ashen Gate and Drearym. Once a wizard's retreat, now consumed by dream-energy.

MAP KEY & LANDMARKS

- Ashen Gate (South):** Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss. The point of no return.
- Waking Guard Outpost:** Day 1. Safe haven with supplies and information. 4 Guards stationed here.
- The Wellspring:** Day 1-2. Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel (see Part 2).
- Ruined Tower of Valdris:** Day 2. Former wizard's tower. Contains a thin point and potential lore about Mordath. DC 14 Investigation to find a hidden journal page.
- Purple Pools:** Thin points between worlds scattered along the road. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark. DC 12 Perception to spot from a safe distance.
- Drearym (North):** Day 3. First major town. Faction tensions between Waking Guard and Dreamseekers.

DM
NOTE

The regional map image shows the Ruined Tower of Valdris, a key landmark. If you'd like a proper top-down regional map of the full Twisted March, I can generate a prompt for you to create one in Artistly. The current image serves as an atmospheric landmark illustration instead.

PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

⚠ DANGER

ARRIVAL

"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles. People eye your Dreambound marks with pity and suspicion."

The town is under martial law. The Waking Guard controls the gates and checks everyone entering. The party's Dreambound marks will be noted — some townsfolk will be hostile, others desperate for help.

KEY LOCATIONS

- 1. The Vigorous Dog (Inn)** — Run by **Marta Greel**, a former adventurer who lost her leg to a nightmare creature. She walks with a peg leg and a hand crossbow. Blunt, practical, and fiercely protective of the town. Her daughter **Lissa** (16) went missing near the Wellspring three days ago. Marta offers **50gp** and a magic item for her safe return.
- 2. Waking Guard Barracks** — **Captain Rena Ashford**, stern but fair. She's holding the town together through sheer will. Asks the party to investigate nightmare sightings on the eastern road (**30gp reward**). Warns them about Brother Caelum: "That priest is going to get people killed with his talk of killing the god."
- 3. Old Town Chapel** — Now the meeting place of the **Dreamseekers**, led by **Brother Caelum**. He preaches that Mordath's death will "free" the Dreambound. The chapel has been defaced — the old holy symbols replaced with crescent moon sigils.
- 4. The Wellspring** — Ancient well outside the eastern wall, leaking purple dream-energy. The water has turned violet. Lissa was last seen here. The area is dangerous — nightmare creatures emerge from the well at night.
- 5. Market Square** — Central gathering place. Refugees trade information and supplies. A notice board has missing persons flyers, bounty notices, and a Dreamseeker recruitment poster.

FACTION: THE DREAMSEEKERS

The Dreamseekers believe that killing Mordath will end the curse and free the Dreambound. They're wrong — killing the god will kill every Dreambound, including the players. The faction is led by **Brother Caelum**, a charismatic priest who genuinely believes he's saving people.

The Truth: Caelum is being manipulated by **The Architect** — a entity within Mordath's dreams that wants the god dead so it can consume his divine essence. The Architect communicates through Caelum's dreams, posing as a benevolent spirit.

The party can interact with the Dreamseekers in several ways: infiltrate them, confront Caelum, or try to turn them against the Architect. Each approach has consequences.

MAP: DREARYM

Town map — Key locations and faction territories



Drearym — A walled market town under siege. Purple water flows through the settlement, corrupting the land. The Waking Guard controls the north gate; Dreamseekers gather in the southeast chapel.

KEY LOCATIONS

- A — **The Vigorous Dog:** Marta Greel's inn. Safe haven. Rooms 5sp/night. Information hub.
- B — **Waking Guard Barracks:** Captain Ashford's headquarters. 12 Guards stationed here. Armory (locked, DC 15).
- C — **Old Town Chapel:** Brother Caelum's Dreamseeker meeting place. Secret basement with ritual chamber.
- D — **Market Square:** Central gathering place. Notice board. Refugee camp in the eastern corner.
- E — **The Wellspring:** Outside the eastern wall. Lissa Greel was last seen here. Dangerous at night.
- F — **North Gate:** Main entrance. Waking Guard checkpoint. Curfew after sunset.

NPCS OF DREARYM

Key characters the party will encounter



Mordath — The Dreaming God, in his current state. His divine form is crumbling, leaking dream-energy into the mortal world.

CAPTAIN RENA ASHFORD — WAKING GUARD

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL GOOD

	STR
	16
	+3
	DEX
	12
	+1
	CON
	14
	+2
	INT
	10
	+0
	WIS
	14
	+2
	CHA
	13
	+1

AC 16 (chain mail) | HP 45 (6d8+12) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Athletics +5, Intimidation +3, Perception +4

Saving Throws: STR +5, CON +4

Equipment: Longsword, shield, chain mail, signal horn, 15gp

Actions: *Longsword.* +5 to hit, 1d8+3 slashing (1d10+3 two-handed).*Signal Horn (1/day).* Blowing the horn summons 2d4 Waking Guard soldiers who arrive in 1d4 rounds.

Personality: Stern, fair, exhausted. She's been holding the town together for six months and it's wearing her thin. She respects competence and despises the Dreamseekers' "kill the god" rhetoric.

BROTHER CAELUM — DREAMSEEKER PRIEST

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL (BELIEVES HE'S GOOD)

	STR
	10
	+0
	DEX
	12
	+1
	CON
	10
	+0
	INT
	14
	+2
	WIS
	16
	+3
	CHA
	18
	+4

AC 13 (chain shirt) | HP 32 (5d8+10) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Deception +6, Insight +5, Persuasion +8, Religion +4

Spellcasting (Cleric 5): Spell save DC 13, +5 to hit. *Cantrips:* guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy. *1st (4 slots):* command, cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith. *2nd (3 slots):* hold person, spiritual weapon, augury. *3rd (2 slots):* spirit guardians, dispel magic.

Dreamseeker’s Blessing: Caelum can cast *detect thoughts* at will (self only) as a bonus action. The Architect grants him this power.

Personality: Charismatic, passionate, genuinely believes killing Mordath will save everyone. He’s being manipulated by The Architect but doesn’t know it. If confronted with evidence, he becomes defensive, then desperate.

MORE NPCs & THE DREAMING WELL

The missing girl and the thin point

MARTA GREEL — INNKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), CHAOTIC GOOD

	STR
	14
	+2
	DEX
	10
	+0
	CON
	16
	+3
	INT
	12
	+1
	WIS
	13
	+2
	CHA
	11
	+0

AC 12 (leather armor under apron) | HP 27 (5d8+5) | Speed 20 ft. (peg leg)

Skills: Intimidation +2, Medicine +3, Survival +4

Equipment: Hand crossbow (+4, 1d6 piercing, 30/120ft), peg leg (can be used as an improvised weapon, +4, 1d4+2 bludgeoning)

Personality: Blunt, practical, fiercely protective. Lost her leg to a Nightmare Spawn six months ago. Lost her husband to the Unbound. Her daughter Lissa is all she has left.

LISSA GREEL — MISSING GIRL

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL GOOD

AC 10 | HP 9 (2d8) | Speed 30 ft.

A 16-year-old girl with her mother’s stubbornness. She’s been trapped in a **Dream Loop** at the Wellspring for three days — reliving her favorite memory (a summer festival with her father before he died) on repeat. She’s physically unharmed but mentally exhausted.

Rescuing Lissa: See the Dreaming Well encounter below. If rescued, she becomes a recurring NPC and potential ally. She has latent dream-sensitivity — she can sense thin points within 30 feet.

ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

The Wellspring is a thin point between the waking world and Mordath’s dreams. The well water has turned violet and bubbles with dream-energy. **Lissa Greel** sits at the well’s edge, eyes open but unseeing, trapped in a loop. **2 Nightmare Spawn** (Shadows with purple tinges) guard the well.

Terrain: The well is 10ft diameter, 15ft deep. Purple liquid fills the bottom 5ft. The area within 10ft of the well is **difficult terrain** (dream-energy makes the ground soft and shifting). Any creature that starts its turn within 5ft of the well must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or be pulled 5ft toward the well.

Rescuing Lissa — Three Options:

Option 1 — Physical Pull: DC 14 Strength (Athletics) check to grab Lissa and pull her from the well’s influence. The Nightmare Spawn attack to prevent this. On failure, the pulling character must make a DC 13 WIS save or be briefly pulled into the dream (stunned until end of next turn).

Option 2 — Enter the Dream: A character can touch the purple water and fail a DC 13 WIS save to enter the dream. Inside: a sunlit festival field, Lissa playing with a man (her dead father). DC 13 Persuasion (Deception doesn’t work — she knows) to convince her to leave. On success, both return. On failure, the character takes 2d6 psychic damage and is ejected.

Option 3 — Disrupt the Thin Point: A character can use an action to attempt to disrupt the dream-energy. DC 14 Arcana check. On success, the thin point destabilizes — the Nightmare Spawn take 3d6 radiant damage and Lissa is freed. On failure, the character takes 2d6 psychic damage.

NIGHTMARE SPAWN

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

Reskinned Shadow (MM p. 269) with the following changes:

Appearance: Purple-tinged shadows with glowing magenta eyes. They smell of ozone and decay.

Damage: Strength Drain deals **psychic** damage instead of necrotic.

Dream Vulnerability: Takes an extra **1d6 radiant** damage from moonlight or effects that simulate moonlight (e.g., the *moonbeam* spell).

Nightmare Aura: Any creature that starts its turn within 10ft of a Nightmare Spawn must make **DC 11 WIS save** or be frightened until the start of its next turn.

**DM
NOTE**

*If a player enters the dream to rescue Lissa, they glimpse Mordath's white throne room and see three glowing keys: a **Bronze Key** (The Architect), a **Silver Key** (The Crown), and a **Gold Key** (The Heart). This foreshadows the quest for Books 2-5.*

PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

⚠ DANGER ⚠

THE GATEHOUSE

A fortress built into a cliff face — the boundary between the waking world and Mordath's consciousness. Once a monastery dedicated to the Dreaming God, now a ruin consumed by dream-energy. The structure has **four wings** connected by a central courtyard:

Dormitory (West): Collapsed. Contains the remains of monks who were here when the curse began. DC 13 Investigation finds **Journal Page** (lore about Mordath's prophecy).

Library (North): Partially intact. Contains lore about Mordath — he was a god of dreams who foresaw his own death and tried to prevent it. His curse is not malicious; it's a divine fever dream, the death-throes of a god.

Chapel (East): The veil is thinnest here. 3 Nightmare Spawn emerge from the walls when anyone enters. DC 13 WIS save or pulled into a brief dream vision of Mordath pleading for help.

Gate Hall (South, Cliffside): The climax. The Dreaming Gate — a massive portal of swirling purple energy. Through it: Mordath's white throne room and the dying god himself.

EXPLORING THE GATEHOUSE

Central Courtyard: A fountain of purple liquid sits in the center. Drinking it (DC 15 CON save) grants **Dreamsense** (detect dream-energy within 60ft) for 1 hour but causes vivid hallucinations (disadvantage on Perception checks for the duration).

Dormitory — Lore: The journal page reads: *"Mordath spoke to us in dreams. He said: 'I have seen my death. It comes not from enemies, but from within. The Architect stirs in my dreams. It wants to wear my crown.' We did not understand. Now we never will."*

Library — Lore: A book titled *"The Dreaming God: A Theological History"* reveals: Mordath was once a mortal who ascended to godhood through the power of collective dreams. He created the Hollow Dominion as a sanctuary for dreamers. The Architect is a fragment of his own psyche — his fear of death — that gained sentience and now seeks to consume him.

Chapel — Encounter: 3 Nightmare Spawn (use stat block from Page 9) emerge from the walls. The chapel's altar has been defaced with the Architect's symbol — an eye within a spiral. DC 14 Religion check to identify it as a corruption of Mordath's original crescent moon symbol.

THE GATE HALL — APPROACHING THE PORTAL

"The Gate Hall opens onto the cliff edge. Before you stands the Dreaming Gate — a massive archway of white stone, easily thirty feet tall, filled with swirling purple energy. Through the portal, you can see a vast white throne room. On the throne sits a figure robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. The figure's chest rises and falls — barely. Dying."

But between you and the portal stands a figure in purple armor, twin blades of crackling pink energy humming in its hands. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow — a weight that presses against your chest like deep water.

This is the **Nightmare Knight** — a Dreambound soul who chose to guard the gate out of duty. It can be fought or reasoned with.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER

THE GUARDIAN

"The figure in purple armor stands before the gate, twin blades of crackling pink energy humming in its hands. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow — a weight that presses against your chest like deep water."

The Nightmare Knight is a **Dreambound soul** — a former guardian of the monastery who chose to stay and protect the gate even as the curse consumed everything. It is not evil, merely bound by duty. It will fight to prevent anyone from entering the gate, believing that approaching Mordath will hasten his death.

Social Encounter Option: The Knight can be reasoned with. DC 15 Persuasion check (DC 12 if the party has rescued Lissa or helped the Waking Guard). On success, it steps aside and warns: "The god is dying. What you do in there will determine whether the Dominion lives or dies with him." On failure, it attacks.

Combat Encounter: If fought, this is a **hard encounter** for a level 3 party. The Knight fights defensively, trying to push characters away from the gate rather than kill them. It surrenders at 20 HP or below, saying: "You are determined. Perhaps... perhaps you are what he has been waiting for."

NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

MEDIUM UNDEAD, LAWFUL NEUTRAL

STR

18

+4

DEX

14

+2

CON

18

+4

INT

12

+1

WIS

14

+2

CHA

16

+3

AC 15 (half plate) | HP 85 (10d8+40) | Speed 30 ft.

Saving Throws: STR +7, CON +7, WIS +4

Damage Resistances: Necrotic; Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Vulnerabilities: Radiant

Condition Immunities: Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned

Senses: Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12

Languages: Common (can't speak, but understands)

Actions:

Multiattack. The Knight makes two Energy Blade attacks.

Energy Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d6+4) slashing damage + 4 (1d8) psychic damage.

*Life Drain (Recharge 5-6).*Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 16 (3d6+4) psychic damage. The Knight regains HP equal to half the damage dealt.

Dream Step (Bonus Action). The Knight teleports up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space it can see. This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Reactions:

Parry. The Knight adds 3 to its AC against one melee attack that would hit it. It must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

Legendary Action (1/round):

Reposition. The Knight moves up to 15 feet without provoking opportunity attacks.

TOUCHING THE GATE

Whether the Knight is fought or reasoned with, a character can touch the Dreaming Gate. On contact:

"The world dissolves into white. You stand in a vast throne room of white stone. On a cracked throne sits a figure robed in fading starlight. Its mask of porcelain is shattered, revealing a face that is both ancient and kind. It speaks directly into your mind: "Three keys. Find them. The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths. Find them before the hollow ones consume everything. Please. I cannot hold on much longer."

Each character who touches the gate gains **Dreamsense** (detect dream-energy within 30 feet, always active) and a vision of three locations that will be explored in Books 2-5.

END OF BOOK 1

Return to Drearym — and a cliffhanger for Book 2

RESOLUTION

- Mordath is dying — not trying to harm anyone. His death-throes are the curse.
- There are **three keys** that can resolve the curse: The Architect, The Crown, The Heart.
- The Architect — a fragment of Mordath's own fear — wants the god dead so it can consume his divine essence.
- Brother Caelum and the Dreamseekers are being manipulated by The Architect.
- The players are Dreambound — tied to Mordath's fate. If he dies, they die.

CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2

"As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum, eyes glowing purple, the Architect's symbol burning on his forehead. His 'sharing circle' was a trap. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force. And he's coming for you next."

TREASURE & REWARDS

GUARDIAN'S LONGSWORD

Longsword, uncommon (requires attunement). This blade crackles with residual dream-energy. +1 to attack and damage rolls. Deals an extra 1d4 psychic damage to undead and fiends. Once per long rest, the wielder can cast *detect thoughts* (DC 13).

MARTA'S GRATITUDE

If Lissa was rescued, Marta gives the party a *Potion of Greater Healing* and a *Cloak of Elvenkind*. She also offers free lodging and information for the rest of the campaign.

MONASTERY JOURNAL

The journal found in the Gatehouse library. Worth 25gp to a collector, but more importantly contains lore about Mordath that will be useful in Books 2-5. DC 15 History check while studying it reveals the location of the Fractured Court (Book 2's starting point).

DREAMBOUND SIGIL

The party's sigils now glow permanently. They can use this to identify other Dreambound (useful for spotting Unbound infiltrators). The sigil also grants advantage on saves against nightmare-based effects.

Milestone: Party reaches level 3 by the end of this adventure.

GM NOTES

Tone: This adventure should feel like waking up in someone else's nightmare. The horror is wrongness — familiar things made strange. The tragedy is that Mordath is not a villain; he's a dying god who created something beautiful that's being consumed by his own fear.

Moral Complexity: Neither the Waking Guard nor the Dreamseekers are wrong. The Guard wants to preserve Mordath's life (and the Dominion). The Dreamseekers want to end the curse (but don't understand the cost). Both goals conflict with the players' survival.

Connections to Book 2: Plant seeds throughout — references to the Fractured Court, Queen Thessaly, the Architect, and the three keys. The cliffhanger army marching on Drearym leads directly into Book 2: *The Fractured Court*.

Scaling: For level 1 parties, reduce the Nightmare Knight's HP to 60 and remove Legendary Actions. For level 4+ parties, add 2 more Nightmare Spawn to the Chapel encounter and give the Knight +10 HP.

